

If you use a software client like Thunderbird, you don't need bother about connectivity too much. Find a place to plug your PC or laptop into the Internet cloud, download all your mail, and disconnect if you can't stay connected. Take action on the mails you receive, type out your replies, connect to the Net, and fire away all those messages in one go—and you're done. This option is something that road warriors who lug their laptops wherever they go might prefer. You might also like this option if you don't care too much about having your mail messages reside with some third-party service.

The second option is to use your Gmail account. We'll show you some nifty tricks to map your regular official mail IDs to your Google account and use that for both sending and receiving without anyone being any the wiser that you are doing this from within Gmail. You could also sign up for the Google Apps service if you have your own domain name.

The biggest disadvantage with option two, though, is the need for a working Internet connection to get things done. As of this writing, this problem hasn't been solved yet. There are groups attacking the issue, and we'll take a peek under the covers to see what we can expect as e-mail evolves into an online/offline combo.

## 6.1 Mozilla Thunderbird

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Thunderbird comes from the Mozilla Foundation, the creators of the runaway hit browser, Firefox. As is to be expected from such a team, Thunderbird is a free, open source, cross-platform (Windows, Linux, Mac), robust e-mail client that you can bend to do whatever you want—like making coffee (by writing your own extension and connecting it to a networked coffee machine)! While we will not delve into such esoteric uses, let's take a look at how you can get productive with Thunderbird.